HITCH ATTACHING FASTENER REPLACEMENT

AFFECTED VEHICLES: **CERTAIN 1997 THROUGH 2000 MODEL YEAR EXPEDITION AND NAVIGATOR EQUIPPED WITH FACTORY INSTALLED TRAILER HITCH**

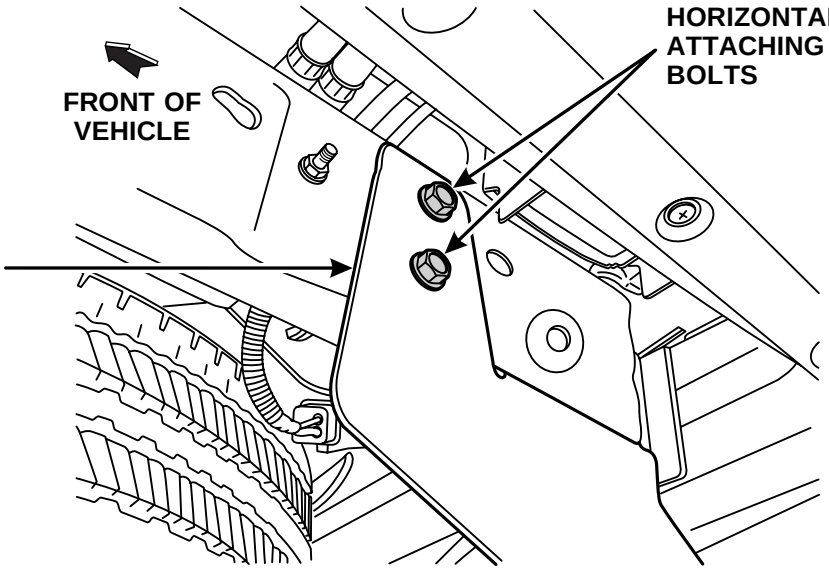
OVERVIEW

This procedure outlines hitch assembly removal, cleaning and reinstallation using updated attaching hardware.

NOTE:
REMOVING THE FRAME WAX AS OUTLINED IN STEP 5 IS CRITICAL TO THE OVERALL ROBUSTNESS OF THIS REPAIR.

SERVICE PROCEDURE

1. Turn off the air suspension switch, then raise and support the vehicle on a hoist.
2. Remove the hitch electrical connector bracket from the hitch assembly.
3. Position two (2) jack stands to support the hitch assembly.
4. Remove all bolts and nut plates attaching the hitch to the frame, then remove the hitch assembly from the vehicle. See Figures 1 and 2.

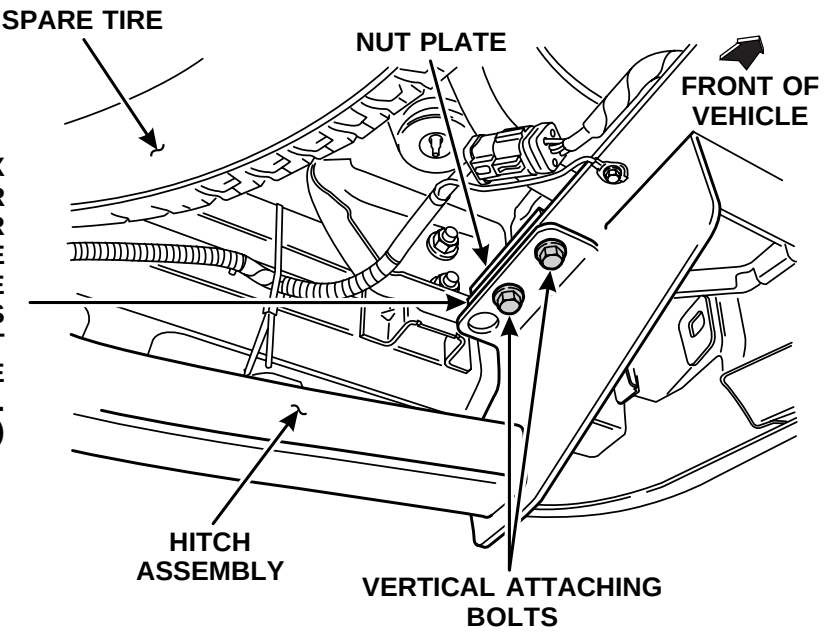


**LEFT SIDE SHOWN,
RIGHT SIDE SIMILAR**

IR00S05A

FIGURE 1

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LEFT SIDE SHOWN, RIGHT SIDE SIMILAR **IR00S05B**

FIGURE 2

5. Using Brake Metal Parts Cleaner (F6AZ-2C410-AB) or equivalent obtained locally, remove the frame wax from all areas where there is hitch- or nut plate-to-frame contact. This includes:
   - the inside areas of the hitch.
   - the inside and outside areas of the frame web.
   - the upper and lower areas of the frame flanges.
6. **CAUTION: To avoid cross threading the bolts into the nut plates, start each bolt by hand and be sure it is threading properly into the nut plate.**

   CAUTION: Do not final tighten any bolts until all have been installed. Be sure to tighten the horizontal bolts first (Step 7) before tightening the vertical bolts (Step 8).

   Reposition the hitch on the jack stands and install the ***new*** bolts and ***new*** nut plates. Only tighten the bolts snug at this time.
7. Tighten the horizontal attaching bolts to 175 Nm (129 lb-ft).
8. Tighten the vertical attaching bolts to 175 Nm (129 lb-ft).
9. Remove the jack stands.
10. Install the hitch electrical connector bracket. For 7-pin connectors, tighten the bolt to 48 Nm (35 lb-ft). For 4-pin connectors, tighten the bolt to 63 Nm (46 lb-ft).
11. Apply a coat of commercially available underbody anti-corrosion compound meeting Ford specification ESR-M7C54-A to the hitch attachment area ensuring adequate coverage.
12. Lower the vehicle and turn on the air suspension switch.

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